

GEOTELA GEO-INTELLIGENCE · ISSUE 05 · FALL 2026

The map was never just about directions.



Launching soon. Join the waitlist at geotela.com

FROM THE FOUNDERS

Every place has a story. Most of us only read the first line.



Think about the biggest decisions you've made: where to live, where to send your kids to school, where to open the shop, where to spend the one week off you get all year. Every single one was a location decision. And most of us made them with a pin on a map and a gut feeling.





We started Geotela because that felt backwards. The information about a place already exists: flood history, road access, growth, who's moving in and why. It's just scattered across dozens of sources, written in a dozen dialects of jargon, and almost never verified.

So we built a way to pull it together, check it three times, and put it on a single card you can actually read. We're a few weeks from opening the doors. This issue is our hello, and a look at how we think about place.

Read it, share it with the friend who's always browsing land listings at midnight, and save your spot on the waitlist.

See you on the map,

The Geotela team

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THE COUNTDOWN • LAUNCH

We're a few weeks out. Here's what's coming.

Geotela is a location intelligence platform. In plain English: we take everything knowable about a place, check it against independent sources, and hand it back to you as something you can read in thirty seconds and trust for thirty years.

01

GeoScore cards

One clear score for a parcel, neighborhood or city, with the factors behind it laid out on a card you can share with your partner, lender or agent.

02

Verified by three

Our 3-attestation rule means no fact lands on a card until three independent sources agree on it. If they don't, you'll know.

03

Stories and signals

A weekly letter with the opportunities we're watching and the location stories behind them.

WHY THE WAITLIST MATTERS

When the doors open, the waitlist walks in first.

Early access goes to people on the list, in the order they joined. You'll also get the weekly newsletter from day one: opportunities, location stories and first looks at new GeoScore cards.

Save your spot at geotela.com

ESSAY

Why a map means more than which way to turn



We've trained ourselves to think of maps as a way to get from A to B. The blue dot, the turn-by-turn voice, the arrival time. Useful, sure. But that's the smallest thing a map can do.



Your location quietly decides a remarkable share of your life. It shapes your commute and your kids' school zone. It sets your insurance premium and your flood risk. It decides how far the nearest hospital is, what the air smells like in August, and whether the land you buy today is worth more or less in ten years.

A good map holds all of that. It's a record of what happened in a place, a snapshot of what's happening now, and, if you read it right, a decent forecast of what's coming next.

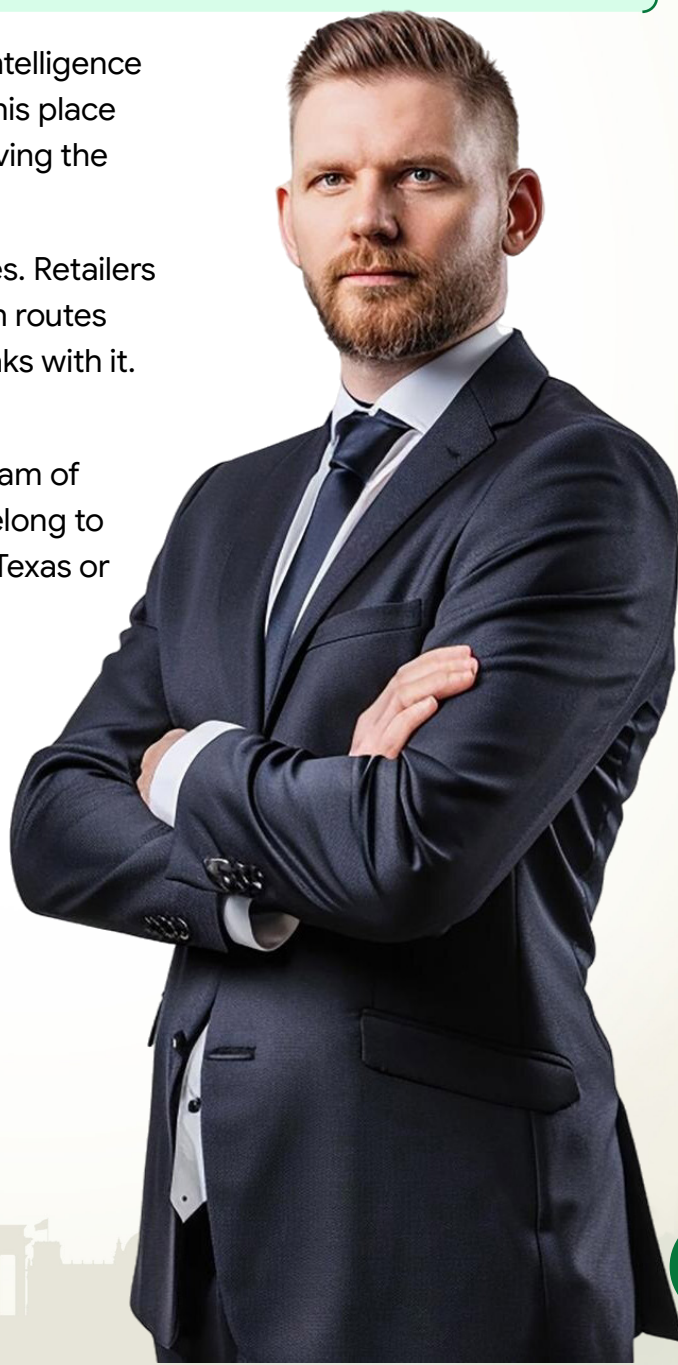


"Directions tell you how to get there. Location intelligence tells you whether you should."

That's the shift we care about. Location intelligence is simply the habit of asking "what does this place know?" before making a decision, and having the data to answer.

Big companies have done this for decades. Retailers pick store sites with it. Delivery fleets plan routes with it. Public-health teams trace outbreaks with it. The next few pages show exactly how.

What's new is that it no longer needs a team of analysts. It can fit on a card. And it can belong to anyone standing at the edge of a field in Texas or Newyork, wondering if this is the one.



CASE STUDIES • PART ONE

Five times a map changed the outcome



Location intelligence sounds new. It isn't. Here's the proof, from a Victorian doctor to a delivery giant.



01 The doctor who mapped a killer

SOHO, LONDON · 1854 · PUBLIC HEALTH

When cholera tore through Soho, most experts blamed "bad air." Dr. John Snow plotted each death on a street map and saw them cluster around one water pump on Broad Street. He persuaded officials to remove the pump handle, and his map became a founding moment of modern epidemiology.



Takeaway: patterns invisible in a spreadsheet jump out on a map.

02 UPS and the art of not turning left

UNITED STATES · 2010S · LOGISTICS

UPS built a routing system called ORION that plans each driver's day around real road geometry, favoring right turns that avoid idling across oncoming traffic. The company has said it saves on the order of 100 million miles a year, along with the fuel and emissions that come with them.



Takeaway: tiny location choices, repeated at scale, become enormous.

03 How Starbucks picks a corner

GLOBAL · ONGOING · RETAIL

Starbucks has long used GIS mapping to decide where new stores go, layering foot traffic, demographics, nearby businesses and the reach of existing stores before signing a lease. The goal: open where demand is, without cannibalizing the location down the block.



Takeaway: The right spot is a calculation, not a hunch.

CASE STUDIES · PART TWO

04 Three words that bring the ambulance

UNITED KINGDOM · 2019 ONWARD · EMERGENCY RESPONSE

What 3 words divided the world into 3-metre squares and gave each a unique three-word name. Many UK emergency services now accept those addresses, helping responders find callers lost on a hillside, a beach or a road with no house numbers. When you can't describe where you are, precise location becomes a lifeline.



Takeaway: Location is only useful if it's precise enough to act on.

05 Walmart, hurricanes and strawberry Pop-Tarts

FLORIDA · 2004 · RETAIL AND WEATHER

As Hurricane Frances approached Florida, Walmart studied what shoppers in the storm's path had bought before earlier hurricanes. Flashlights, sure. But also strawberry Pop-Tarts, which sold several times faster than usual, and beer. Trucks were loaded accordingly and headed for stores in the forecast cone.



Takeaway: Place plus timing predicts behavior better than either alone.

THE PATTERN

What all five have in common

They layered data. One map is a picture. Deaths plus pumps, weather plus sales: that's an insight.

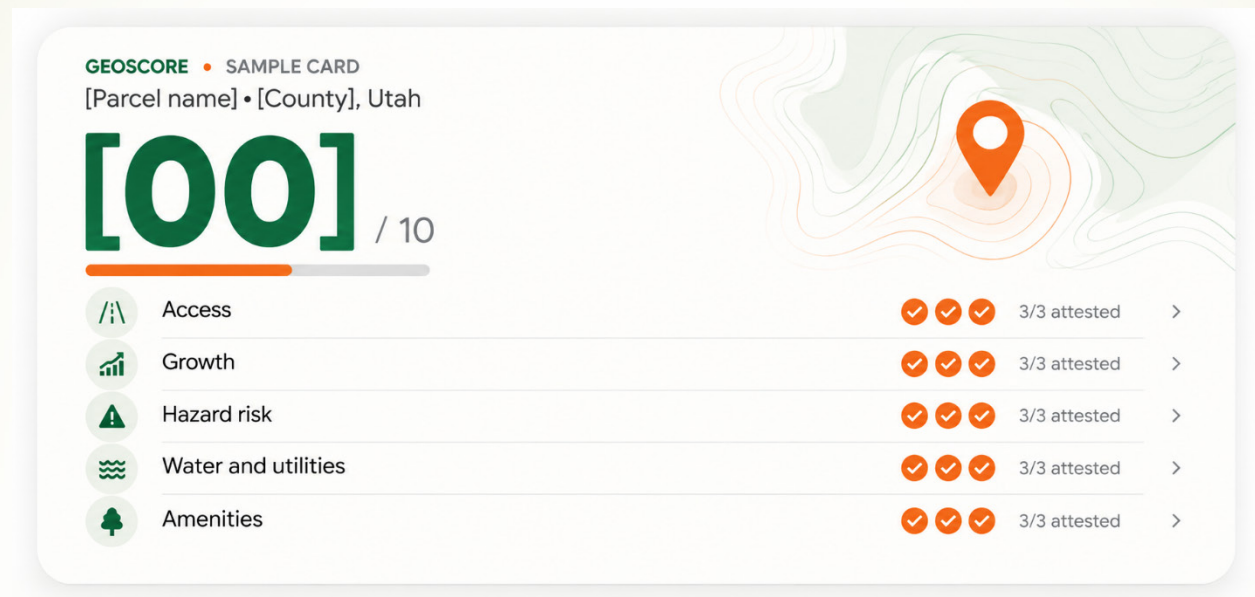
They trusted evidence. Each broke from the popular assumption because the location data said otherwise.

They acted early. The value came from moving before everyone else could see what they saw.

Geotela puts that same playbook in your pocket, whether you're buying five acres or picking a weekend getaway.

WHAT MAKES US DIFFERENT

One score. Three witnesses.



The GeoScore: a whole place, at a glance

A GeoScore rolls the things that matter about a location into one number from 0 to 10, then shows its work. Tap any factor and you see what drove it, from road access to flood exposure to growth nearby.

The 3-attestation rule: trust, built in

Here's the part we're proudest of. No data point makes it onto a card until three independent sources confirm it. Public records, geospatial data and on-the-ground verification have to agree. If they don't, we don't publish it as fact. We flag it.

It's slower than scraping a listing. It's also the reason people trust the card enough to sign on the line.

	THE USUAL WAY	THE GEOTELA WAY
Where facts come from	Often one seller or one data feed	Three independent sources, every time
Risk	Buried in disclosures	Scored and shown up front
When sources disagree	You rarely find out	It's flagged, not published as fact
Format	Pages of listings and PDFs	One card you can read and share



REAL BUYERS • TEXAS [REPLACE WITH VERIFIED, CONSENTED QUOTES]

They saw the card. Then they bought the land.

We tested the Geoscore card in our community. Here's what early users told us after a GeoScore card helped them say yes.



I'd been scrolling listings outside for months. The GeoScore card was the first thing that showed me flood risk, road access and water in one place, and told me where each fact came from. - John, TX



The three-source rule sold me. I'd been burned before by a listing that "forgot" an easement. Seeing every data point attested gave me the confidence to make an offer the same week. - Sharma, TX



I sent the card to my wife and our lender that afternoon. Nobody had to decode a forty-page PDF. We're breaking ground on our project this fall. - Owens, TX



Your parcel could be next. [Join the waitlist at geotela.com](https://geotela.com)

WHERE TO GO

The top 5 trips of 2026, and why now



Great trips come from great timing. Each pick has a reason this year is the year, plus a Geotela lens: the location insight that makes the trip better.

1 Rome, Italy

Why 2026: U.S. News ranked it the single best vacation of the year, and the city is fresh off the 2025 Jubilee, when landmarks and piazzas got a serious polish.



GEOTELEA LENS: Stay in Monti or Testaccio. Walkable to the ruins, with neighborhood prices and neighborhood food.

2 Giza and Cairo, Egypt

Why 2026: The Grand Egyptian Museum is finally fully open, putting Tutankhamun's treasures together under one roof within sight of the pyramids. It's the biggest museum opening in a generation.



GEOTELA LENS: Book near Giza, not downtown. You'll trade Cairo traffic for sunrise at the plateau.

3 Route 66, USA

Why 2026: The Mother Road turns 100 this year. Towns from Chicago to Santa Monica are celebrating the centennial, and it's the perfect excuse for the great American road trip.



GEOTELA LENS: Don't skip the Texas Panhandle: Amarillo's Cadillac Ranch and the route's midpoint in tiny Adrian.

4 Tasmania, Australia

Why 2026: Australia's island state is having a moment: award-winning whisky, farm-to-table dining you can't find elsewhere, and new expedition cruises into the wild, World Heritage-listed southwest that few people ever see.



GEOTELA LENS: Seasons are flipped. Plan for December to March, the southern summer, for long days and open trails.



5 Penang, Malaysia

Why 2026: CNN flagged it as one of the year's best places to go, and it earns the spot. George Town's UNESCO-listed old quarter mixes Chinese clan houses, colonial streets and some of the best hawker food in Asia, for a fraction of what you'd pay elsewhere.



GEOTELA LENS: Plan by street, not by attraction. The old quarter is compact and rewards wandering.

TRAVEL SMARTER

How to read a destination like a local

Zoom in before you book. Check the hotel's block at street level. A "central" stay next to a highway ramp isn't central.

Map the weather, not the date. Rainy seasons, heat waves and hurricane windows follow geography. Plan around them.

Follow the locals' lunch. Walk two streets past the main square. Prices drop and the food gets honest.

Check the elevation. Hills change walking times, views and even how you'll sleep. The map knows.

WHERE TO WATCH

5 places on the rise

Emerging doesn't mean unknown. It means the data is moving before the crowd does.



Dallas–Fort Worth - TEXAS, USA

Why: PwC and the Urban Land Institute rank it the top U.S. real estate market to watch again, powered by job growth and a steady stream of new arrivals. **Watch:** land on the metro's edge along growing highway corridors.





Hartford - CONNECTICUT, USA

Why: Realtor.com's forecast puts it at the top for 2026 growth. It's a "refuge market" for buyers priced out of Boston and New York, with a stable insurance-industry job base.

Watch: tight inventory pushing prices up.

Northwest Arkansas - FAYETTEVILLE–BENTONVILLE, USA

Why: Steady population gains, lower entry prices and big corporate anchors have turned a quiet corner of the Ozarks into a smaller-metro standout. **Watch:** trail-town lifestyle drawing remote workers.

Tashkent - UZBEKISTAN

Why: A new Center for Islamic Civilization, a wave of international hotel openings and easier travel are putting the Silk Road capital on the map. **Watch:** tourism infrastructure along the Samarkand–Bukhara route.

Nairobi - KENYA

Why: Rapid urbanization and a booming tech scene, often called the "Silicon Savannah," are driving demand for housing and offices. **Watch:** regulatory complexity; local expertise matters here.

Market picks are for inspiration, not investment advice. Always do your own due diligence and talk to a licensed professional before you buy.



OUR RECOMMENDATIONS

The field kit: six questions to ask before you buy land

- 01 **Where does the water go?** Check FEMA flood maps, then walk the land after a rain if you can.
- 02 **Who owns what's underneath?** In Texas, mineral rights are often sold separately. A title search will tell you.
- 03 **Can you legally get there?** A dirt track isn't access. Confirm deeded road frontage or a recorded easement.
- 04 **What are you allowed to build?** Look at zoning, nearby city rules and any deed restrictions before you dream.
- 05 **Where will water and power come from?** Ask about well depth nearby and how far the nearest utility line runs.
- 06 **Will the soil work for you?** No sewer? A perc test tells you if a septic system is even possible.

More from our desk

READ

The Ghost Map by Steven Johnson

The full, gripping story of John Snow's cholera map. A page-turner about how place explains everything.

TRY

Look up your own parcel

Your county appraisal district's website shows lot lines, values and history. It's free and eye-opening.

DRIVE

Route 66 across Texas

A short stretch through the Panhandle packs in neon, diners and the road's halfway point.



LOCATION STORIES

3 stories history almost forgot

Some of the world's most remarkable places hide in plain sight, or right under your feet.



CAPPADOCIA, TÜRKIYE

The city found behind a living-room wall

In 1963, a man renovating his home in Derinkuyu knocked through a wall and found a tunnel. It led to an entire underground city, carved from soft volcanic rock and dropping many levels deep, with air shafts, wells, stables, chapels and heavy rolling-stone doors.

It could shelter thousands of people and their animals when invaders came. Today it's one of dozens of underground towns in the region.

Location lesson: the land beneath a parcel can matter as much as what's on top.





POHNPEI, MICRONESIA

A capital built on the sea

Off the coast of a tiny Pacific island sits Nan Madol: nearly a hundred artificial islets built from stacked basalt columns on top of a coral reef, laced with canals. It was the seat of the Saudeleur dynasty, and how they moved the massive stones is still debated.

UNESCO listed it as a World Heritage site in 2016. Few travelers have ever heard of it.

Location lesson: people have always engineered the land to fit their ambitions.

FAYETTE COUNTY, TEXAS

Cathedrals hiding in country churches

Between Houston and San Antonio, plain white churches in farm towns like High Hill, Praha, Dubina and Ammannsville hold a surprise. Czech and German immigrants painted their interiors with vivid ceilings, stenciled vines and faux marble to echo the cathedrals they left behind.

They're known as the Painted Churches of Texas, and tours still run from nearby Schulenburg.

Location lesson: every county has a story. It's part of what you buy into.



Stories like these land in your inbox every week. geotela.com



JOIN US

Get the map before the market does.

Join the Geotela waitlist and you're first in line when we launch. You'll also get our free weekly newsletter, packed with opportunities and location stories you won't find anywhere else

EVERY WEEK

The opportunity

A place, a trend or a parcel type we think deserves a closer look, and why.

EVERY DAY

The story

A location story that'll make you the most interesting person at dinner.

EVERY WEEK

The breakdown

One GeoScore card, explained factor by factor, so you learn to read land like a pro.



Save your spot

Join the waitlist at geotela.com

Free · Weekly · Unsubscribe anytime

Know someone eyeing land, a move or a trip? Send them this issue.



STAY ON THE MAP

Follow Us on Instagram/Tiktok @Usegeotela.

Launch-day news, behind-the-scenes, and location stories too good to keep to ourselves. Follow us on social for more.

Join the waitlist for early access and the weekly newsletter: geotela.com

